

Through the Traveler's Gaze: Three Films of José Luis Guerín

It was on a late-winter evening, in the pandemic-deserted streets of Strasbourg's student quarter, La Krutenau—during one of my countless wanderings in the wake of heartbreak, retracing the steps of a young Johann Wolfgang von Goethe, then a law student here, just a few years before the publication of his proto-Romantic *The Sorrows of Young Werther*, which quietly set forth rhymes and reasons for unrequited love destined to echo for centuries—that I came across *Dans la ville de Sylvia*. Little did I know, that its filmmaker—the Catalonia-born José Luis Guerín—had been drawn to this very place sixteen years earlier for similar reasons, and had done almost the same thing: drifting through the city's medieval island in search of lost love, guided by the traces of Goethe's sorrowful young hero. Nor did I know that this same figure had aligned himself with a familiar lineage of cineastes who had also profoundly nurtured my cinephilia: the Lumières, Chaplin, Lubitsch, Ford, Ozu, Bresson, among others—it was as if discovering another member of the 'artistic ancestry' I had come to admire.

Indeed, taking a small Spanish crew to the village of Cong in Ireland to make a documentary (*Innisfree*) revisiting the town where, almost forty years earlier, director John Ford—steeped in Hollywood, yet with an Irish origin that resonated through his work—had filmed an iconic American picture, is precisely the kind of thing I could imagine myself doing at the fledgling age of thirty. In much the same spirit, the year of my birth saw the theatrical release of Guerín's *Tren de sombras*, a film set in France's Normandy region, nostalgically looking back at the birth of cinema with a heartfelt tribute to its inventors¹—who, as though destined, bore a name meaning 'light,' to which the film's titular 'shadows' stand as complement: such is all one needs to make cinema, any genuine admirer of F. W. Murnau and German Expressionism would maintain—a true sign of love. At the other end of the spectrum, while never intentionally detaching from his Spanish roots, Guerín's arguably most 'Barcelonese' work, *En construcción*—centered on the construction of a modern apartment building in the city's marginal 'El Xino' quarter—was conceived from the perspective of a visitor. Thus, even within his homeland, Guerín approached cinema with a sense of foreignness, of someone who sees himself both inside and outside a given location. One might say that the cineaste is at once an artist with a peculiar sense of place and a restless traveler, navigating both the physical world and the ever-evolving cinematic landscape.

The Cartography of Memory

“—What is exile? She asked me. What shall I tell you?
Shall I say: it is the love between land and dreams?
Or the sigh of a flower, away from her own garden?

¹The inventors of cinema referenced here are the Lumière brothers, Auguste and Louis, whose famous development of the motion picture recording, processing, and projection system, the *Cinématographe*, is often considered the birth of the medium.

Or the wandering of a vision, looking for its memories?”
— Sherko Bekas²

It was as if moving from place to place, for Guérin, was a way of finding his artistic identity, having distanced himself from the national identity granted by birth. One way to understand an artist in search of inspiration is through the figure of the wanderer—a soul without a harbor, compelled to drift until meaning reveals itself. This trope of the struggling artist, though romanticized, persists for good reason: time and again, we encounter stories of those, real or fictional, who, unable to find grounding or self-belief, turn to movement—literal or figurative—until an encounter sparks the dormant artistry within.³ Much like the protagonist of *Sylvia*, whose memories of a woman he once met led him back to Strasbourg—quite aptly, a city touched by and that continues to harbour German Romanticism, lingering in shadowed reverie—Guérin’s return mirrored that of his cinematic alter ego. Roaming through streets, squares, cafés, and tram platforms, Guérin carved out his image of the real-life Sylvie from the many faces he encountered, just as his character would later do on screen.

As recounted in the companion piece *Unas fotos en la ciudad de Sylvia*—a mesmerizing compilation of stills and moving images documenting his path—Guérin had met Sylvie in a Strasbourg bar twenty-two years earlier. Her name’s Spanish equivalent, Sylvia, carried a special resonance for him,⁴ christening the film’s French and Spanish titles, though the character remained as Sylvie. The return was driven by his search for her, but that was not all. Like many lovelorn dreamers of the Romantic tradition, Guérin identified with Goethe’s Werther, whose yearning for Charlotte rang with Dante’s vision of Beatrice, and Petrarch’s longing for Laura. These figures, and the cities tied to their memory—Strasbourg,⁵ Florence, Avignon—formed a lineage that Guérin’s travels seemed to restage.

Movement thus became a way for Guérin to breathe life into his idea, until it took form as inseparable from the places that inspired it. Guérin and his character’s journeys through Strasbourg reflect this ethos: each is anchored by sites imbued with meaning, fragments of memory bound to the image of a woman whose face may already have faded. It is the act of moving with only a handful of ‘memory-anchors’ and of gazing at faces that could never quite match the age of the beloved, but which sustain the fantasy, that reanimates her illusionary

²Sherko Bekas, *Butterfly Valley*, trans. Choman Hardi (Todmorden: Arc Publications, 2018), 85.

³A notable film employing this struggling artist trope is *Portrait of Jennie* (1948), directed by the Hollywood German émigré William Dieterle, which Guérin memorably evokes in his travelogue documentary *Guest*.

⁴Here we see a subtle counterpoint to Guérin’s stance on national identity. The woman he searched for in Strasbourg, as recounted in *Unas fotos*, is French, yet he recalls her by her Spanish equivalent, Sylvia—so strongly that it appears in the French title of the fiction film, *Dans la ville de Sylvia* (one of the two official bilingual titles, due to the Spanish-French co-production), even though it is never mentioned in the film itself. Similarly, the actress Pilar López de Ayala, who plays the woman mistaken for Sylvie, is Spanish, speaking French to the Spanish protagonist with a discernible Spanish accent. His Spanish identity, it seems, despite being deliberately held at a distance, still finds its way into the work—perhaps less as assertions than as incidental echoes.

⁵Technically, Strasbourg—or the Alsace region more broadly—though still upholding the imprint of its German heritage, with German as the main spoken language at the time and bordering Werther’s milieu—is neither the setting for nor the place where *Werther* was conceived. Yet Guérin insisted on its tie to the character of Werther, especially in *Unas fotos*, which reflects strongly his desire to align his personal story with the Romantic tradition.

presence. This culminates in the film's most memorable café-terrace sequence, where fragmented glances coalesce into a single woman framed behind a glass window, an amalgam of the others before her. Out of this emerges the protagonist's pursuit, convinced of her significance, threading through the memory-anchors and ending in disillusion. Therein, Guérin's movement becomes a kind of cartography of memory—tracing the veins of the ancient island into a topography on which his montaged recollections are inscribed⁶—ending in the tram, recalling Murnau's *Sunrise*, its glass panes evoking cinema screens where shadows and light are forever in motion.

Beyond the National Cinema

"I've been to Paris, France, and I've been to Paris, Paramount. Paris, Paramount is better."
— Ernst Lubitsch⁷

Distrustful of national logic, Guérin's attachment to the 'old men' of cinema traces back to an older mode of viewing the medium, enduring until the 1950s, when fixed notions of locale and strong national identity had yet to take hold, owing to historical, socio-economic, or institutional forces. For modern viewers—particularly those accustomed to national cinema as a collective identity—it may appear incongruous to see numerous Paramount's late-'20s and '30s romantic and musical comedies unfold in exoticized miniatures of European cities, recreated on Californian soundstages, where all converse in English and perform American-like etiquette.⁸ Enthusiasts would even contend that the aesthetic we now call 'classical Hollywood' owes much to European émigrés, many of which having fled the continent under Nazi threat. It is no less telling that a select cohort of towering figures from Soviet montage, German Expressionism, and French Poetic Realism were revered even within this commercial factory, and that rich currents of exchange flowed among the filmmaking spheres of France, Italy, Germany, and Spain. Cinema was then—and in part still remains—a shared heritage, a transnational art forged through restless migrations of talent and the circulation, blending, or resistance of foreign sensibilities, much as the Renaissance once crystallized from ceaseless movements of ideas and artisans across Europe. Even the 1950s *Cahiers du cinéma* film magazine circle, aiming to dismantle received notions of the seventh art with their *Nouvelle Vague*,⁹ did not deny this legacy; nor did Golden Age Japanese studio masters like Ozu, who at the start of his career,

⁶This idea is indebted to Javier Acevedo Nieto and María Marcos Ramos, "Tren de Sombras: An Aesthetic of Memory," *L'Atalante. Revista de estudios cinematográficos* 26 (July–December 2018): 41–54.

⁷Ernst Lubitsch, quoted in Jonathan Rosenbaum, *Goodbye Cinema, Hello Cinephilia: Film Culture in Transition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2010), 117.

⁸Paramount, renowned for its visual glamour among the 'Big Five,' exemplifies this trend most clearly, but it can also be seen in the romantic and musical comedies of, e.g., MGM and Universal from that era. It is worth noting that during the classical period (1920s–1960s), each Hollywood studio was characterized by a distinct artistic identity, in contrast to the later era of multinational conglomerates. This period also saw the institutionalization of cinema, in which narrative conventions connecting actions into coherent sequences, and illusionist filmic techniques—such as close-ups, eye-line and directional matches, oblique camera positions, and modeled lighting—were standardized to immerse the spectator in a constructed, self-sufficient fictional world. Noël Burch's theory of the Institutional Mode of Representation, as proposed in *Praxis du cinéma* (Paris: Gallimard, 1969), offers a useful lens for this period of cinema, not only in Hollywood, but also, for example, in France and Italy.

⁹Also known as the French New Wave.

confessed little interest in Japanese films.¹⁰ “Cinema is a territory of travelers,”¹¹ Guerín declared, and the phrase seems to aptly gather all these passages into a single truth.

Is wandering, after all, so different from traveling? Perhaps not, when both are guided by shifting purpose—least of all for those, like Guerín, who proclaim their art a pursuit of ‘vision’. Both give shape to ideas, much in the tradition of the Lumières, who traveled with their *Cinématographe* to capture fragments of the world.¹² Or, to borrow that a little too famous line from J. R. R. Tolkien—a phrase that holds a special pride of place among my astronomer friends, who see themselves as wanderers of the night sky, directing their obsessions not to earthly faces but to distant stars: “Not all those who wander are lost.”¹³

And yet, where there's travel, there is exile. The most beautiful cinema of exile, for me, belongs to John Ford. None has captured the longing for homeland, the ache of nostalgia, with such mythic poignancy as Ford in his visions of Ireland and the Irish-American diaspora. I still recall the spring I first encountered his films: nineteen, recently left my coastal hometown in northern Vietnam for the capital, with the other side of the globe yet to come—and his images spoke to me—a homesick youth—with a force that felt utterly personal, though Ford's characters, their dilemmas, their faiths and traditions, shared little with my own. One might go so far as to say nostalgia itself was Ford's true medium: brought to him unwillingly through the exile imposed by his parents' migration; it lent his work a singular depth. Among his oeuvre, *The Quiet Man* remains the most memorable of Ford's returns to Ireland—what film could have resonated more deeply with Guerín, himself a self-exiled artist, than that? In the view of Spanish critic Miguel Marías, it is remarkable—and 'un-Spanish'—that Guerín chose to make *Innisfree* as his second feature,¹⁴ especially given the distance of its subject from his own milieu; and more remarkable still is its indirect approach: a documentary that hardly sings of *The Quiet Man* itself, but of its lingering presence in the daily lives of Cong's townspeople, and above all in the legendary myths and memories of the village elders. What better way to honor a legend than through those who tell their own?

The Obsessed Cineaste's Refuge

“Mac, you ever been in love?”

“No, I've been a bartender all my life.”

— *My Darling Clementine* (1946)

Romanticism characteristically enshrined the image of the suffering artist—one marked by a psychic or worldly scar that becomes an inexhaustible source of creation, much like the

¹⁰David Bordwell, *Ozu and the Poetics of Cinema* (London; Princeton, NJ: British Film Institute; Princeton University Press, 1988), 8.

¹¹José Luis Guerín, interview by Gabe Klinger, 24fps Magazine, July 19, 2008, archived at <https://web.archive.org/web/20080719124740/http://www.24fpsmagazine.com/Archive/Guerin.html>

¹²In *Guest* (2010), a film born from footage Guerín shot while traveling to international film festivals, the filmmaker draws an intriguing analogy to the Lumière brothers' use of their *Cinématographe*: they even brought it everywhere with a tripod, much like a painter traveling with a canvas mounted on an easel.

¹³J. R. R. Tolkien, *The Fellowship of the Ring*, vol. 1 of *The Lord of the Rings* (New York: Ballantine Books, 1972), 231.

¹⁴Miguel Marías, "Innisfree," *Senses of Cinema*, April 14, 2009, <https://www.sensesofcinema.com/2009/cteq/innisfree/>

inspiration the Muses impart to their artists in Greek mythology. Many figures to whom Guerín paid tribute, particularly in his three cine-conscious films of exile, were artists of obsession, driven by material fixations or spiritual visions, their impulse tempered by traces they could neither ignore nor outrun. And it is often, for better or worse, the works born under such obsessions that forever altered the medium. Ford's stubborn devotion to myth and faded ideals—to lost or departed love, to community, to the values of origin—has silently nourished generations of filmmakers across continents and ideologies, so much so that, as film historian Joseph McBride put it—borrowing W. H. Auden's words about Yeats¹⁵—"He became his admirers."¹⁶ It is evidently difficult to imagine cinema without Hitchcock's charged gaze of forbidden desire and suspicion, or—though perhaps to a lesser extent—Preminger's shadows of psychological cruelty; nor without Ozu's relentless pursuit of form or Bresson's¹⁷ austere devotion to a ritualized realism. To say they lived through, and within, their obsessions is hardly an exaggeration. For obsession entails a distance from reality, a voluntary exile of the spirit. The obsessed artist is, in a sense, forever exiled, even when not physically cast out by circumstance, finding refuge in art, where yearning transforms from pathology into inspiration.

Continuing his practice of journeying to cinema's homelands, Guerín's *Tren de sombras* goes beyond homage. Set in Le Thuit, Normandy, this meta-documentary stages the recovery of the amateur silent cinematographer Gérard Fleury's reels. In them—family outings, fleeting gestures, and above all the glance of Fleury's sister-in-law—Guerín seemingly discerns a secret, teased out through rewinding, slowing, enlarging, juxtaposing. As though probing the very machinery of the photographic image, he seeks the spiritual within the mechanical, along the exacting rhythm of Bresson. Here the theme of unrequited and forbidden desire, of idealized beauty as artistic inspiration, which would soon find its full weight in *Sylvia* and later collapse into the black hole of *La academia de las musas*, first began to exert its pull. And as the professor of the titular academy observes, "without the muses, poetry becomes solipsistic madness," so it may be the muse that ennobles obsession, shaping it into something beyond mere affliction and giving form to the artist's otherwise formless fixations.

To complete this constellation of artist and muse, Guerín invoked Dante's Beatrice and Petrarch's Laura—the phrase "Laure, je t'aime" appears scrawled across Strasbourg's walls in *Sylvia*—figures whose visions of lost love stand in continuity with, though not entirely identical to, Goethe's Romantic tragedy. The medieval and Renaissance poets, who elevated longing into poetic transcendence, recall Ford's myth of the departed beloved, and together they counterbalance the obsessive, unreciprocated desires defining *Sylvia*'s Hitchcockian narrative, uniting the voyeurism of *Rear Window* with the fetishized pursuit of *Vertigo*.¹⁸ The city becomes

¹⁵Ireland's national poet William Butler Yeats, whose poem *The Lake Isle of Innisfree* inspired the title of Guerín's 1990 film.

¹⁶Joseph McBride, *Searching for John Ford* (Jackson, MS: University Press of Mississippi, 2011), 718.

¹⁷The narrative structure of *Sylvia*, which chronicles the three nights (and days) of the young artist identified as 'the Dreamer,' is a direct reference to Robert Bresson's *Quatre nuits d'un rêveur* (*Four Nights of a Dreamer*, 1971), itself a loose adaptation of Fyodor Dostoyevsky's *White Nights*, a tale of unreciprocated longing.

¹⁸The Hitchcock references in the pair of films revolving around *Sylvia* also include *Psycho* (1960)—another classic laden with obsession. In *Some Photos*, an envelope with an image of Bates Motel is shown among a stack of letters.

a layered stage: on one level, the timeless tale of *l'amour fou*; on another, the documentary texture of present-day life—children and elders, locals and immigrants, workers and lovers, even the homeless—living outside Romantic illusions. By pushing desire toward its highest ideals and transfiguring unreturned love into muse-like figures, Guerín erected an imaginary locale, a spiritual terrain where all his artistic ideas, obsessions, and fantasies find home, and through which all his literary and cinematic influences—claimed or self-proclaimed—have already traveled, a terrain as old as civilization yet interrogated by modern cameras, as trams traverse the medieval island in mirrored motion—their bells and motors mingling with the cathedral's tolls and the quotidian murmur of urban life, in an almost Bressonian soundscape—so too does Sylvia's vision entwine with them, reaching its final note as the tram recedes across the sunset square, the quieting island enduring in the closing image.

Abstract and amorphous as it may be, cinema as an intangible territory has long stirred passions and drawn those adrift, astonishing in its youth among the arts. Finding one's way through this realm often comes with guidance: through media and publicity, through recommendations and insights, or through engaged cinephile circles—each opening paths toward different locales. For me, it is Guerín who has woven together every sacred influence of cinema and every life experience into something that resonates so profoundly. I fell in love with *Sylvia* in the aching final days of my stay in Strasbourg, before continuing my exile in another city—a city I have not left since—and the film, through its sense of place, imprinted Strasbourg upon my memory with an image most singular and dear, even as its fiction reflected back hidden parts of myself. For a great fiction is a mirror for the viewer's soul, as much as a great documentary is a window onto the world, in the spirit of Guerín;¹⁹ and each return to *Sylvia* reflects another version of myself—often fragmented—illuminated anew, in any place, at any time. Even now, elsewhere, with reverent thoughts of a sublime beloved—much as Dante envisioned Beatrice, rather than the clumsy Wertherian imitation I indulged four years ago—the film gives meaning to my wanderings, across real landscapes as well as within the inner landscapes of the mind, the latter perhaps fated for those in their 'roaring twenties,' lending beauty and purpose to existence. Is this not what we, humans—the only beings who consciously seek their reflection in mirrors,²⁰ the only ones, though a small subset, who venture against instinct into being lost for the sake of discovery—ultimately search for in art?

Films mentioned:

Sunrise: A Song of Two Humans (1927), dir. F. W. Murnau

¹⁹In an interview with Gabe Klinger, Guerín described *En construcción*—primarily documentary—as “a window into a reality, rather than a mirror.” When the interviewer contrasted this with *Tren de sombras*—a fiction cloaked as a documentary, or the other way around, depending on which angle one takes—suggesting it functions more like a mirror, Guerín did not dispute the point (Guerín, interview with Klinger). In fact, each of his films contains both documentary and fictional elements—one may predominate at times, but neither ever fully eclipses the other, as the three films highlighted here demonstrate.

²⁰This perspective is influenced by a writing in Từ Yên Nguyễn Thu Thủy, *Soi gương* [Mirror-Gazing] (Hanoi: Vietnam Women's Publishing House, 2023), 30.

My Darling Clementine (1946), dir. John Ford

The Quiet Man (1952), dir. John Ford

Rear Window (1954), dir. Alfred Hitchcock

Vertigo (1958), dir. Alfred Hitchcock

***Innisfree* (1990), dir. José Luis Guerín**

Tren de sombras (Train of Shadows, 1997), dir. José Luis Guerín

En construcción (Work in Progress, 2001), dir. José Luis Guerín

Unas fotos en la ciudad de Sylvia (Some Photos in the City of Sylvia, 2007), dir. José Luis Guerín

En la Ciudad de Sylvia / Dans la ville de Sylvia (In the City of Sylvia, 2007), dir. José Luis Guerín

La academia de las musas (The Academy of Muses, 2015), dir. José Luis Guerín

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